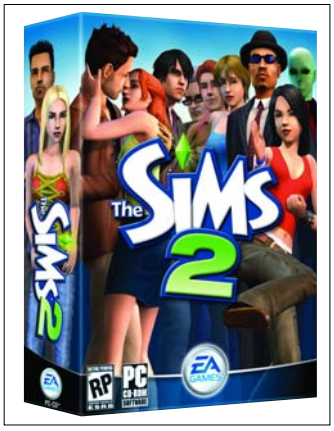
New York Times, November 18, 2004

The Top 10 Games of The Year



THIS YEAR, THE gaming industry surpassed the movie industry in terms of revenue, making it a landmark year for gaming freaks. Some of the best titles were released this year, and who are we to complain. Charles Herold of the New York Times gives his top 10 games of the year It has been a great year for games.

Some, like Doom 3 and Fable, did not quite live up to the hype. Several of the most promising ones, like Knights of the Old Republic II: The Sith Lords and Prince of Persia: Warrior Within, will not be released until after this column appears.

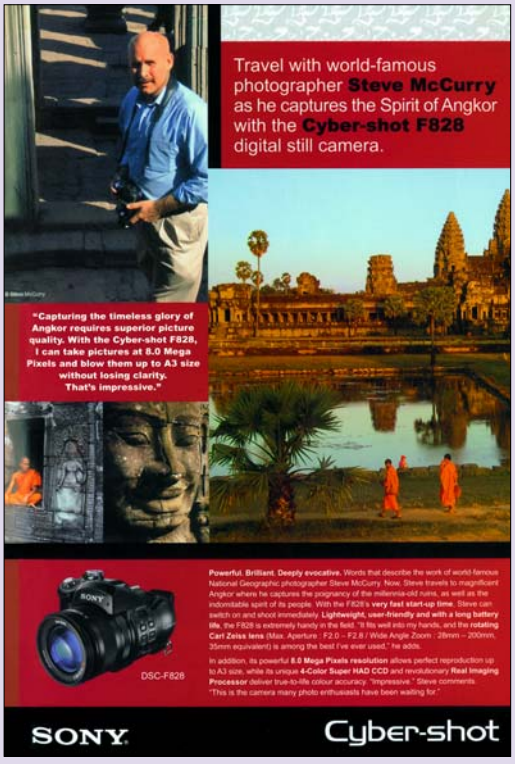
Even so, it is difficult to limit myself to a top-10 list. How can I leave out Pikmin 2 and the Suffering and the Chronicles of Riddick and Halo 2 and Curse of Blackmoor Manor and Sly 2: Band of Thieves and N.F.L. Street and Call of Duty? It's a shame it isn't this difficult every year.

BURNOUT 3: TAKEDOWN The ultimate arcade racing game, Burnout 3 is designed to drive the player into the state of giddy excitement that can only come from careering down freeways, swerving past passenger cars and trying to drive opponents off the road in a shower of glass shards and twisted metal. The game makes driving recklessly seem like so much fun that you shouldn't be allowed to sit behind the wheel of a real car until at least an hour after playing. (Developed by Criterion and published by Electronic Arts for PlayStation 2 and the Xbox; $49.99; for ages 13 and older.)

THE SIMS 2 Unlike the rest of the known world, I was never addicted to the original life simulation game, The Sims, a cute little dollhouse that drew in a lot of people who were not otherwise interested in video games. I never felt much attachment to the game's tiny denizens. The Sims 2 refined the formula, making the characters more realistic (they age now), the situations more involving and surprising, and the interface more fluid. It has been a while since I played the game, yet I still think of my Sims as being alive. I hope they are doing O.K. without me. (Developed by Maxis and published by Electronic Arts for Windows 98 and later; Macintosh version scheduled for spring; $49.99; for ages 13 and older.)

CITY OF HEROES The notion of a city overflowing with superheroes was mocked in the Tick comic books, but the online role-playing game City of Heroes makes it seem like a pretty good idea. The degree of customization in looks and powers allows every superhero to be different, making the game as much about coming up with the coolest design as about saving the world. (Developed by Cryptic Studios and published by NCsoft for Windows 98 and later; $39.99 plus monthly subscription fee; for ages 13 and older.)

To read the complete list of the top 10 games of the year according to The New York Times, go to snipurl.com/top10games



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